

THE LAST TRAIN NORTH

Written by

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An original screenplay

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FADE IN:

EXT. RAIL YARD - NIGHT

Sodium lights buzz over rows of dead freight cars. Snow drifts through the beams.

MAYA REYES (30s, grease-stained overalls, eyes that never stop scanning) walks the line with a flashlight, tapping each coupling with a wrench.

Clang. Clang. Then -- a hollow thunk.

She stops. Crouches. Something is taped under the car: an envelope.

MAYA
(to herself)
You've got to be kidding me.

She tears it open. Inside: a single ticket. NORTHERN LINE. ONE WAY. Tomorrow's date.

And her name, handwritten.

INT. YARD OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

A space heater rattles. OTIS (60s, cardigan over a union jacket) nurses a thermos of coffee and a crossword.

Maya slaps the ticket on his desk.

MAYA
Who's been under car nine?

OTIS
Nobody's been under car nine since
the Carter administration.

MAYA
Then explain this.

Otis studies it. Something passes over his face -- recognition, maybe fear -- and is gone.

OTIS
(too casual)
Kids. Pranks. Toss it.

MAYA
Kids don't know my middle name,
Otis.

He doesn't answer. He folds his crossword. Very carefully.

EXT. MAYA'S APARTMENT BUILDING - NIGHT

A three-story walk-up beside the tracks. A freight train THUNDERS past, rattling every window.

INT. MAYA'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - NIGHT

Dishes. Unopened bills. A photo on the fridge: Maya, younger, beside a WOMAN in a conductor's cap.

Maya props the ticket against the photo. Stares at both.

On the radio, an OLD SONG plays low.

*Oh the last train north is leaving,
and I won't be on it again.*

MAYA (V.O.)

My mother used to say every train goes somewhere. You just have to decide if it's somewhere you want to be. I decided a long time ago. I decided to stay. I decided to keep the lights on and the bills paid and my head down, because somebody had to, because when she left there was nobody else, and because leaving is just a word people use when they don't want to say running.

MAYA (V.O.) (CONT'D)

But she never said what to do when the train comes looking for you.

She picks up the phone. Dials. Waits.

INTERCUT - MAYA'S APARTMENT / OTIS'S TRUCK

Otis answers, driving through snow.

OTIS

It's two in the morning.

MAYA

You knew her handwriting. Didn't you.

A long silence. Wipers thud.

OTIS
Get on the train, Maya.

He hangs up.

CUT TO:

EXT. NORTHERN LINE PLATFORM - DAWN

Maya, duffel over one shoulder, steps onto a train that shouldn't exist -- brass fittings, velvet curtains, steam curling from its wheels.

FLASHBACK - THE SAME PLATFORM - 1996

YOUNG MAYA (8) holds her mother's hand. The same train. The same steam.

THE END